

12 Socioemotional Development in Early Adulthood

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Stories of Life-Span Development: Gwenna's Pursuit and Greg's Lack of Commitment

Commitment is an important issue in a romantic relationship for most individuals. Consider Gwenna, who decides that it is time to have a talk with Greg about his commitment to their relationship (Lerner, 1989, pp. 44–45):

She shared her perspective on both the strengths and weaknesses of their relationship and what her hopes were for the future. She asked Greg to do the same. Unlike earlier conversations, this one was conducted without her pursuing him, pressuring him, or diagnosing his problems with women. At the same time, she asked Greg some clear questions, which exposed his vagueness.

"How will you know when you are ready to make a commitment? What specifically would you need to change or be different than it is today?"

"I don't know," was Greg's response. When questioned further, the best he could come up with was that he'd just feel it.

"How much more time do you need to make a decision one way or another?"

"I'm not sure," Greg replied. "Maybe a couple of years, but I really can't answer a question like that. I can't predict my feelings."

And so it went.

Gwenna really loved this man, but two years (and maybe longer) was longer than she could comfortably wait. So, after much thought, she told Greg that she would wait till fall (about ten months), but that she would move on if he couldn't commit himself to marriage by then. She was open about her wish to marry and have a family with him, but she was equally clear that her first priority was a mutually committed relationship. If Greg had not reached that point by fall, then she would end the relationship—painful though it would be.

During the waiting period, Gwenna was able to not pursue him and not get distant or otherwise reactive to his expressions of ambivalence and doubt. In this way she gave Greg emotional space to struggle with his dilemma, and the relationship had its best chance of succeeding. Her bottom-line position ("a decision by fall") was not a threat or an attempt to rope Greg in, but rather a clear statement of what was acceptable to her.

When fall arrived, Greg told Gwenna he needed another six months to make up his mind. Gwenna deliberated a while and decided she could live with that. But when the six months were up, Greg was uncertain and asked for more time. It was then that Gwenna took the painful but ultimately empowering step of ending their relationship.

Love is of central importance in each of our lives, as it is in Gwenna's and Greg's lives. Soon we will explore the many faces of love, as well as the diversity of adult lifestyles, aspects of marriage and the family, and the role of gender in relationships. To begin, though, we will return to an issue we initially raised in the introductory chapter of this text: stability and change. ■

Stability and Change from Childhood to Adulthood

For adults, socioemotional development revolves around adaptively integrating our emotional experiences into enjoyable relationships with others on a daily basis. Young adults like Gwenna and Greg face choices and challenges in adopting lifestyles that will be emotionally satisfying, predictable, and manageable for them. Clearly they do not come to these tasks as blank slates. Do their decisions and actions simply reflect the persons they had already become when they were 5 or 10 or 20 years old?

Current research shows that the first 20 years of life lay the foundation for an adult's socioemotional development (Petrovic & others, 2023). And there is also every reason to believe that experiences in early adulthood influence a person's future (Mikulincer & Shaver, 2023). A common finding is that the smaller the time intervals over which we measure socioemotional characteristics, the more similar an individual will look from one measurement to the next. Thus, if we measure an individual's self-concept at age 20 and then at age 30, we will probably find more stability than if we measured the individual's self-concept at age 10 and then at age 30.

In trying to understand the young adult's socioemotional development, it would be misleading to look at an adult's life only in the present, ignoring the unfolding of social relationships and emotions (Elam & others, 2023). So, too, it would be a mistake to search only through a 30-year-old's first five to ten years of life in trying to understand why he or she is having difficulty in a close relationship (Vaillancourt-Morel & others, 2022). To further explore stability and change, let's examine attachment.

Attachment appears during infancy and plays an important part in socioemotional development (Bianciardi & others, 2023). We've discussed its role in infancy and adolescence. How do these earlier patterns of attachment and adults' attachment styles influence the lives of adults?

Although relationships with romantic partners differ from those with parents, romantic partners fulfill some of the same needs for adults as parents do for their children (Wendolowska & others, 2022).

Recall that *securely attached* infants are defined as those who use the caregiver as a secure base from which to explore the environment. Similarly, adults may count on



How are attachment patterns in childhood linked to relationships in emerging and early adulthood?

(left) BLOOM Image/Getty Images
(right) Jade/Blend Images/Getty Images

their romantic partner to be a secure base to which they can return and obtain comfort and security during stressful times (Mikulincer & Shaver, 2023).

Do adult attachment patterns with partners reflect childhood attachment patterns with parents and parental sensitivity in infancy? In a retrospective study, Cindy Hazan and Phillip Shaver (1987) found that young adults who were securely attached in their romantic relationships were more likely to describe their early relationship with their parents as securely attached. In a longitudinal study, infants who were securely attached at age 1 were securely attached 20 years later in their adult romantic relationships (Steele & others, 1998). Also, a longitudinal study revealed that securely attached infants were in more stable romantic relationships in adulthood than their insecurely attached counterparts (Salvatore & others, 2011). A longitudinal study found that insecure avoidant attachment at 8 years of age was linked to a lower level of social initiative and prosocial behavior and a higher level of social anxiety and loneliness at 21 years of age (Fransson & others, 2016). Further, a recent study revealed that compared with stable securely attached infants at 12 and 18 months, individuals who were characterized as stable insecurely attached at 12 and 18 months had worse emotion-regulation strategies in relationship-challenging contexts 20 to 35 years later (Girme & others, 2021). And in a longitudinal study that followed individuals from age 13 to age 72, avoidant attachment declined across the lifespan, and being in a relationship predicted lower levels of anxious and avoidant attachment across adulthood (Chopik, Edelstein, & Grimm, 2019). However, in another longitudinal study, links between early attachment styles and later attachment styles were weakened by stressful and disruptive experiences such as the death of a parent or instability of caregiving (Lewis, Feiring, & Rosenthal, 2000).



How Would You...?

As a human development and family studies professional, what current theory and research would you use to explain to clients the connection between infant and adult attachment?

Adults' attachment can be categorized as secure, avoidant, or anxious:

- **Secure attachment style.** Securely attached adults have positive views of relationships, find it easy to get close to others, and are not overly concerned with or stressed out about their romantic relationships. These adults tend to enjoy sexuality in the context of a committed relationship and are less likely than others to have one-night stands.
- **Avoidant attachment style.** Avoidant individuals are hesitant about getting involved in romantic relationships, and once they are in a relationship, they tend to distance themselves from their partner.

secure attachment style An attachment style that describes adults who have positive views of relationships, find it easy to get close to others, and are not overly concerned or stressed out about their romantic relationships.

avoidant attachment style An attachment style that describes adults who are hesitant about getting involved in romantic relationships and once they are in a relationship tend to distance themselves from their partner.

- **Anxious attachment style.** These individuals demand closeness, are less trusting, and are more emotional, jealous, and possessive.

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The majority of adults (about 60 to 80 percent) describe themselves as securely attached, and not surprisingly adults prefer having a securely attached partner (Zeifman & Hazan, 2008). Researchers are studying links between adults' current attachment styles and various aspects of their lives. For example, a recent study of young adult dating couples revealed that dating duration influenced the relationship between dating quality and attachment insecurity, with anxious attachment becoming a better predictor of lower satisfaction and lower commitment in long-term than in short-term relationships (Freeman, Simons, & Benson, 2023). Also, a recent study in four European countries found that adult attachment security predicted the quality of intimate couple relationships during the COVID-19 lockdown (Eder & others, 2021). In addition, securely attached adults are more satisfied with their close relationships than are insecurely attached adults, and the relationships of securely attached adults are more likely to be characterized by trust, commitment, and longevity (Simpson & Karantzas, 2019). In a recent research review, having an insecure attachment style increased the risk of engaging in suicidal thoughts (Zortea, Gray, & O'Connor, 2021). Also, in a recent study, college students with an anxious attachment style were more likely to be addicted to social networking sites (Liu & Ma, 2019). And, in a recent meta-analysis, adults with insecure attachment styles were more likely to engage in risky sexual behaviors (Kim & Miller, 2020).

If you have an insecure attachment style, are you stuck with it and does it doom you to have problematic relationships? Attachment categories are somewhat stable in adulthood, but adults do have the capacity to change their attachment thinking and behavior (Mikulincer & Shaver, 2023). Although attachment insecurities are linked to relationship problems, attachment style is only one factor that contributes to relationship functioning; other factors also contribute to relationship satisfaction and success (Peri-Rotem & Skirbekk, 2023). Later in the chapter, we will discuss some of these factors in our coverage of marital relationships.



What are some key dimensions of attachment in adulthood, and how are they related to relationship patterns and well-being?
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Love and Close Relationships

Love refers to a vast and complex territory of human behavior, spanning a range of relationships that includes friendship, romantic love, affectionate love, and consummate love (Sternberg & Sternberg, 2019). In most of these types of love, a recurring theme is intimacy.

Intimacy

Self-disclosure and the sharing of private thoughts are hallmarks of intimacy (Roddy & others, 2020). Adolescents have an increased need for intimacy. At the same time, they are engaged in the essential tasks of developing an identity and establishing their independence from their parents. Juggling the competing demands of intimacy, identity, and independence also becomes a central task of adulthood. In a recent study, greater self-disclosure was associated with higher relational intimacy offline but with lower relational intimacy online in romantic relationships but not friendships (Lee, Gillath, & Miller, 2019).



Why is intimacy an important aspect of early adulthood?
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Recall that Erik Erikson (1968) argued that identity versus identity confusion—figuring out who we are, what we are all about, and where we are going in life—is the most important issue to be negotiated in adolescence. In early adulthood, according to Erikson, after individuals are well on their way to establishing stable and successful identities, they enter the sixth developmental stage, which is intimacy versus isolation. Erikson described intimacy as finding oneself while losing oneself in another person, which requires a commitment to another person.

Development in early adulthood often involves balancing intimacy and commitment on the one hand, and independence and freedom on the other. At the same time that individuals are trying to establish an identity, they face the challenges of increasing their independence from their parents, developing an intimate relationship with another individual, and continuing their friendship commitments. They also face the task of making decisions for themselves instead of relying on what others say or do.

Friendship

Increasingly, researchers are finding that friendship plays an important role in development throughout the life span (Vieth, Rothman, & Simpson, 2022). Most U.S. men and women have a best friend. Ninety-two percent of women and 88 percent of men have a best friend of the same sex (Blieszner, 2009). Many friendships are long-lasting, as 65 percent of U.S. adults have known their best friend for at least 10 years and only 15 percent have known their best friend for less than 5 years. Adulthood brings opportunities for new friendships; when individuals move to new locations, they may establish new friendships in their neighborhood or at work (Blieszner & Ogletree, 2018).

Romantic and Affectionate Love

Although friendship is included in some conceptualizations of love, when we think about what love is, other types of love typically come to mind. In this section we explore two widely recognized types of love: romantic love and affectionate love.

Romantic Love

Some friendships evolve into **romantic love**, which is also called passionate love, or *eros*. Romantic love has strong components of sexuality and infatuation, and as well-known love researcher Ellen Berscheid (2010) has found, it often predominates in the early part of a love relationship. A meta-analysis found that males show higher avoidance and lower anxiety about romantic love than females do (Del Giudice, 2011).

A complex intermingling of different emotions goes into romantic love—including passion, fear, anger, sexual desire, joy, and jealousy (Buller & others, 2023). Sexual desire is the most important ingredient of romantic love (Berscheid, 2010). Obviously, some of these emotions are a source of anguish, which can lead to other issues such as depression. One study found that a relationship between romantic lovers was more likely than a relationship between friends to be a cause of depression (Berscheid & Fei, 1977). Another study revealed that a heightened state of romantic love in young adults was linked to stronger depression and anxiety symptoms but better sleep quality (Bajoghli & others, 2014). Other researchers found that declaring a relationship status on Facebook was associated with both romantic love and jealousy (Orosz & others, 2015).

Can romantic involvement bring benefits? In a recent study, interacting with a romantic partner and investing time and effort in the relationship predicted greater well-being (Hudson, Lucas, & Donnellan, 2020). However, these effects were moderated by relationship quality, as researchers found

romantic love Also called passionate love, or *eros*; romantic love has strong sexual and infatuation components and often predominates in the early period of a love relationship.

that being in a relatively neutral relationship was associated with lower well-being than being unpartnered.

Online Romantic Attraction In today's world, relationships between romantic partners are formed not only in person but also over the Internet (Lenton-Brym & others, 2021). In a 2022 national poll, single adults who had never been married (52 percent) or who were living with a partner (46 percent) were the most likely to report having ever used an online dating service (Vogels, 2022). By comparison, 36 percent of Americans who are divorced, separated or widowed said they had ever used a dating site or app, while 16 percent of married adults said the same.

In a recent study of 1.8 million online daters from 24 countries, in every country a person's resource-acquisition ability (as indicated by level of education and income) in romantic dating choice was positively linked to the amount of attention they received from other site users (Jonason & Thomas, 2022). Also in this study, resource-acquisition ability increased the attention received by men almost 2.5 times that of women, with the gender difference occurring in every country.

Is looking for love online more likely to be successful than meeting a potential partner face-to-face? Online dating sites claim that their sites often have positive outcomes. A poll commissioned by Match.com reported that twice as many marriages occurred between individuals who met through an online dating site as between people who met in bars, clubs, and other social settings.

Some critics argue that online romantic relationships lose the interpersonal connection, whereas others emphasize that the Internet may benefit shy or anxious individuals who find it difficult to meet potential partners in person. One problem with online matchmaking is that many individuals misrepresent their characteristics, such as how old they are, how attractive they are, and their occupation. Recent data indicate that men lie most about their age, height, and income; women lie most about their weight, physical build, and age (Statisticbrain.com, 2017). Despite such dishonesty, researchers have found that romantic relationships initiated on the Internet are more likely than relationships established in person to last for more than two years (Bargh & McKenna, 2004). And in a large-scale study of more than 19,000 individuals, it was discovered that more than one-third of relationships that lead to marriage now begin online and that the resulting marriages are slightly less likely to break up and are characterized by slightly higher marital satisfaction than marriages that begin with contact in offline contexts (Cacioppo & others, 2013).

Romantic Relationship Changes in Emerging Adulthood How do romantic relationships change in emerging adulthood? In one study spanning 10 years, short-term relationships were supported more as individuals moved into emerging adulthood (Lantagne, Furman, & Novak, 2017). Long-term adolescent relationships were both supportive and turbulent, characterized by elevated levels of support, negative interactions, higher control, and more jealousy. In emerging adulthood, long-term relationships continued to provide high levels of support, while negative interactions, control, and jealousy decreased.

Affectionate Love Love is more than just passion (Langeslag & van Steenbergen, 2020). **Affectionate love**, also called companionate love, is the type of love that occurs when someone desires to have the other person near and has a deep, caring affection for the person (Clark, Hirsch, & Monin, 2019). According to a recent study of almost 8,000 individuals in 37 countries, affectionate touch such as stroking, hugging and kissing is a relatively stable characteristic of human romantic relationships that is robustly and reliably related to the degree of reported love between partners (Sorokowska & others, 2023).



What characterizes online romantic attraction?
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How Would You...?

As a social psychologist, what research-based information would you give to college students regarding the likelihood that an online relationship will last?



affectionate love In this type of love, also called companionate love, an individual desires to have the other person near and has a deep, caring affection for the other person.

The early stages of love often focus on romantic interest and sexual attraction, but as love matures, passion tends to give way to affection (Berscheid, 2010). Phillip Shaver (1986) proposed a developmental model of love in which the initial phase of romantic love is fueled by a mixture of sexual attraction and gratification, a reduced sense of loneliness, uncertainty about the security of developing another attachment, and excitement from exploring the novelty of another human being. With time, he says, sexual attraction wanes, attachment anxieties either lessen or produce conflict and withdrawal, novelty is replaced with familiarity, and lovers find themselves either securely attached in a deeply caring relationship or distressed—feeling bored, disappointed, lonely, or hostile, for example. In the latter case, one or both partners may eventually end the relationship and then move on to another relationship.

Consummate Love

So far we have discussed two forms of love: romantic (or passionate) and affectionate (or companionate). According to Robert J. Sternberg (1988; Sternberg & Sternberg, 2019), these are not the only forms of love. Sternberg proposed that love can be thought of as a triangle with three main dimensions—passion, intimacy, and commitment. Passion involves physical and sexual attraction to another. Intimacy relates to the emotional feelings of warmth, closeness, and sharing in a relationship. Commitment is the cognitive appraisal of the relationship and the intent to maintain the relationship even in the face of problems.

In Sternberg’s theory, the strongest, fullest form of love is *consummate love*, which involves all three dimensions (see Figure 1). If passion is the only ingredient in a relationship (with intimacy and commitment low or absent), then the partners are merely *infatuated*. An example might be an affair or a fling in which there is little intimacy and even less commitment. A relationship marked by intimacy and commitment but low or lacking in passion is called *affectionate love*, a pattern often found

among couples who have been married for many years. If passion and commitment are present but intimacy is not, Sternberg calls the relationship *fatuous love*, as when one person worships another from a distance. But if couples share all three dimensions—passion, intimacy, and commitment—they experience consummate love (Sternberg & Sternberg, 2019). In a recent cross-cultural study of more than 7,000 individuals in 25 countries, the universality of Sternberg’s triarchic theory was confirmed (Sorokowski & others, 2021).

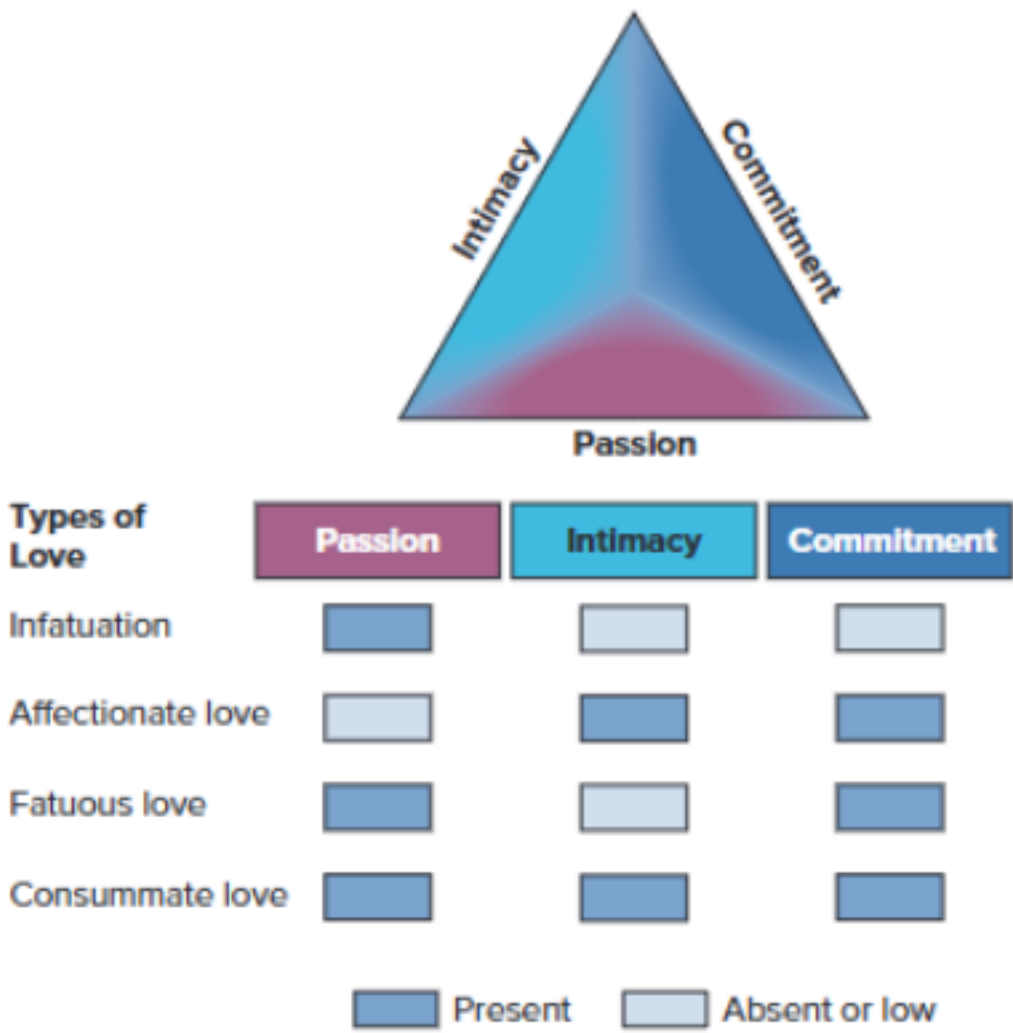


Figure 1 Sternberg’s Triangle of Love.

Sternberg identified three dimensions of love: passion, intimacy, and commitment. Various combinations of these dimensions result in infatuation, affectionate love, fatuous love, and consummate love.

more diffused in love because of the strong group emphasis on connections outside of a romantic love relationship. By contrast, in individualistic countries such as the United States and most European countries, intimacy is often intensified because an individual’s social network is likely to be smaller and less group oriented (Gao, 2016). Also, research indicates that U.S. romantic relationships involve greater passion than Chinese romantic relationships (Gao, 2001). And researchers have found that self-disclosure

Cross-Cultural Variations in Romantic Relationships

Culture has strong influences on many aspects of human development, and romantic relationships are no exception (Joo & others, 2022; Sorokowski & others, 2023). In collectivist countries like China and Korea, intimacy is

is more common in U.S. romantic relationships than in Japanese romantic relationships (Kito, 2005). Feelings of commitment are stronger in Chinese romantic relationships than in U.S. romantic relationships (Dion & Dion, 1993).

In an exploration of cross-cultural variations, romantic relationships were examined in three countries—Japan, France, and Argentina (Ansari, 2015). In Japan, the marriage rate is rapidly decreasing to the point that the Japanese government is concerned that this decline might lead to a considerable drop in Japan's population. In 2013, 45 percent of Japanese women 16 to 24 years of age reported that they were not interested in or despised having sexual contact. Also, the percentage of Japanese men and women who aren't involved in any romantic relationship has increased significantly in recent years.

In Argentina, romantic interest is much stronger than in Japan (Ansari, 2015). Sexual and romantic flirtation is a way of life for many Argentinians. Online dating is not nearly as frequent as in the United States, apparently because men are so forward in their romantic pursuits in person.

In France, as in Argentina, interest in passionate love is strong. However, in the three-country comparison, one aspect of French interest in romantic relationships stood out—their affinity for having extramarital affairs. In one comparison, only 47 percent of those surveyed in France reported that having an extramarital affair is morally wrong, compared with 69 percent in Japan and 72 percent in Argentina (Wike, 2014). In this survey, 84 percent of people in the United States said infidelity was morally wrong. In sum, there are striking cultural variations in many aspects of romantic relationships.

In the previously mentioned exploration of romantic relationships in different countries, the Middle Eastern country of Qatar also was studied (Ansari, 2015). In Qatar, casual dating is forbidden and public displays of affection can be punished with prison time. However, with the recent advent of smartphones, social media, and the Internet, young adults in Qatar are contacting each other about co-ed parties in hotel rooms, a private way to hang out away from the monitoring of parents, neighbors, and government officials.



What are some characteristics of romantic relationships in China?
Lane Oatley/Blue Jean Images/Getty Images



What are romantic relationships like in Argentina?
JAG IMAGES/Cultura RF/Getty Images

Adult Lifestyles

A striking social change in recent decades has been the decreased stigma attached to individuals who do not maintain what were long considered conventional families. Adults today choose from many different lifestyles and form many types of families (Gehart, 2024). They live alone, cohabit, marry, divorce, and remarry partners of the same or opposite sex.

In his book *The Marriage-Go-Round*, sociologist Andrew Cherlin (2009) concluded that the United States has more marriages and remarriages, more divorces, and more short-term cohabiting (living together) relationships than most other countries. Combined, these lifestyles create more turnover and movement in and out of relationships in the United States than in virtually any other country. Let's explore these varying relationship lifestyles.

Single Adults

Recent decades have seen a dramatic rise in the percentage of single adults. In 2021, 46.4 percent of individuals 18 years of age and older were single in the United States, inching ever closer to half (U.S. Census Bureau, 2022). Consider how dramatic the rise in single adults is—the percentage of single adults in 1970 was only 28 percent! The increasing number of single adults reflects rising rates of cohabitation and a trend toward postponing marriage. The United States has a lower percentage of single adults than many other countries such as Great Britain, Germany, and Japan. The fastest

increase in the proportion of single adults is occurring in rapidly developing countries such as China, India, and Brazil (Klinenberg, 2013).

Common challenges faced by single adults may include the difficulty of forming intimate relationships with other adults, confronting loneliness, and finding a niche in a society that is marriage-oriented. Bella DePaulo (2011, 2023a, b) argues that society has a widespread bias against unmarried adults that is seen in everything from missed perks in jobs to deep social and financial prejudices.

Advantages of being single include having time to make decisions about one's life course, time to develop personal resources to meet goals, freedom to make autonomous decisions and pursue one's own schedule and interests, opportunities to explore new places and try out new experiences, and privacy (DePaulo & Kislev, 2023).

In a 2019 Match.com national survey of more than 35,000 U.S. single adults, *fast sex and slow love* characterized their responses (Fisher & Garcia, 2019). In terms of fast sex, 66 percent of U.S. singles reported having had a one-night stand, 34 percent had sex with someone before a first date, and 54 percent had experienced an uncommitted, secretive friends-with-benefits relationship (Fisher & Garcia, 2019). However, in terms of slow love, today's singles are taking far longer than past generations to commit to love and marriage, wanting to know everything they can about a potential partner before investing time, effort, and money to make a formal commitment (Fisher & Garcia, 2019). And even though uncommitted sexual experiences are much more common among today's singles, they still have a strong interest in finding romantic love. In this poll, more than 54 percent of U.S. singles said they believe in "love at first sight," 86 percent reported that they want to find a committed partner they can live with forever, and 89 percent responded that they believe it is possible to remain married to the same person for the rest of one's life.

In the most recent Match.com (2022) survey of 5,000+ single adults, an increase in "conscious dating" had occurred, with singles taking a smarter approach in looking for a partner and building relationships. Singles increasingly preferred casual first dates and said that dating helped them learn about new people and become a better version of themselves. Single adults have emerged post COVID-19 as transformed daters,

changing their priorities and dating smarter. They now look for a partner who prioritizes mental health and self-care; they want someone who is emotionally mature and socially responsible; they are less fixated on good looks; and they are widening their dating pool. Singles are dating intentionally and looking for a long-term, committed partner.



How Would You...?

As a social worker, what research-based information regarding "fast sex and slow love" might be important for counselors to understand?

Cohabiting Adults

Cohabitation refers to living together in a sexual relationship without being married. Cohabitation rates in the United States have risen in recent years, and aspects of cohabitation have changed (Di Nallo & others, 2023).

In 2022, among 18- to 29-year-olds, 20 percent of women and 15 percent of men were in cohabiting relationships, while among 30- to 39-year-olds, equal numbers of women and men (26 percent) were in cohabiting relationships (Marino, 2022). Cohabitation also varied by ethnic/racial groups in 2022. Among 18- to 29-year-olds, cohabitation rates were as follows: bi/multiracial (15 percent), Black (13 percent), Latino (14 percent), Asian (9 percent), and non-Latino White (21 percent). In the 30- to 39-year-old group, cohabitation rates were as follows: bi/multiracial (27 percent), Black (14 percent), Latino (26 percent), Asian (19 percent), and non-Latino White (31 percent).

Engaging in serial cohabitation—exiting one cohabitation and then entering another—also has increased in the last decade in the United States (Eickmeyer & Manning, 2020). And at lower SES levels, couples are more likely to cohabit and give birth prior to



What are some potential advantages and disadvantages of cohabitation?
LWA/Dann Tardiff/Blend Images LLC

marriage and less likely to marry at all (Karney, 2021). In addition, a recent study indicated that early transitioning into a stepfamily home, especially for women, was linked to earlier entry into cohabitation (Johnston, Cavanaugh, & Crosnoe, 2020).

Cohabitation rates are higher in some countries than they are in the United States. In Sweden, for example, cohabitation before marriage is virtually universal (Smock & Schwartz, 2020). Cohabitation is increasing in China and Taiwan but still rare in Japan and South Korea.

Some couples view their cohabitation not as a precursor to marriage but as an ongoing lifestyle (Klinenberg, 2013). These couples do not want the official aspects of marriage. In the United States, cohabiting arrangements tend to be short-lived, with one-third lasting less than a year (Hyde & DeLamater, 2023). Fewer than 1 out of 10 last five years or more. Of course, it is easier to dissolve a cohabitation relationship than a marriage.

Couples who cohabit face certain problems (Foran & others, 2022). Disapproval by parents and other family members can place emotional strain on the cohabiting couple. Some cohabiting couples have difficulty owning property jointly. Legal rights on the dissolution of the relationship are less certain than in a divorce.

Recent research confirmed that cohabitation is a risk factor for intimate partner violence in emerging adults (Manning, Longmore, & Gordano, 2018). Researchers also have found that cohabiting individuals are not as mentally and emotionally healthy as their counterparts who are in committed marital relationships (Memitz, 2018). For example, in a recent study, although there were no differences between cohabiting couples and married couples at the initial assessment in relationship adjustment, cohabiting mothers who stayed with their partner over the 10 years showed significantly greater declines in relationship adjustment over the 10 years compared with married mothers (Foran & others, 2022).

If partners live together before they marry, does cohabiting help or harm their chances of later having a stable and happy marriage? The majority of studies have found lower rates of marital satisfaction and higher rates of divorce in couples who lived together before getting married (Kreidl & Žilincikova, 2021). For example, in a recent national survey, married adults had higher rates of relationship satisfaction than unmarried adults who cohabited (Horowitz, Graf, & Livingston, 2019).

What might explain the finding that cohabiting is linked with divorce more than not cohabiting? The most frequently given explanation is that the less traditional lifestyle of cohabitation may attract less conventional individuals who are not great believers in marriage in the first place. An alternative explanation is that the experience of cohabiting changes people's attitudes and habits in ways that increase their likelihood of divorce. A recent study in nine European countries found that spending more time in unmarried cohabitation was associated with increased tolerance of divorce (Kreidl & Žilinciková, 2021).

Research has provided clarification of cohabitation outcomes. One meta-analysis found the negative link between cohabitation and marital instability did not hold up when only cohabitation with the eventual marital partner was examined, indicating that these cohabitators may attach more long-term positive meaning to living together (Jose, O'Leary, & Moyer, 2010). Also, one study found that cohabiting did not have a negative effect on marriage if the couple did not have any previous live-in lovers and did not have children prior to the marriage (Cherlin, 2009). Another study concluded that the risk of marital dissolution between cohabitators (compared with individuals who married without cohabiting) was much smaller when they cohabited in their mid-twenties and later (Kuperberg, 2014).

How Would You...?

As a clinical psychologist, what research-based information would you use to illustrate the potential pros and cons of cohabitation to a young couple?



Married Adults

Until about 1930, stable marriage was widely accepted as the endpoint of adult development. In the last 70 to 80 years, however, personal fulfillment both inside and outside marriage has emerged as a goal that competes with marital stability. The changing



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norm of equality in marriage and increasingly high expectations for marriage have produced marital relationships that are more fragile and intense than they were for earlier generations (Gehart, 2024). A study of 502 newlyweds found that nearly all couples had optimistic forecasts of how their marriage would change over the next four years (Lavner & Bradbury, 2013). Despite their optimistic forecasts, however, their marital satisfaction declined across this time frame. Wives with the most optimistic forecasts showed the steepest declines in marital satisfaction. Also, in a recent study conducted in a variety of countries and religions, men reported higher marital satisfaction than women across a number of countries (Sorokowski, Kowal, & Sorokowska, 2019), and levels of marital satisfaction were similar for Muslims, Christians, and atheists.

Some characteristics of marital partners predict whether the marriage will last longer (Van Scheppingen & Leopold, 2020). Two such characteristics are education and ethnicity. A survey of more than 22,000 women found that women and men with a bachelor's degree were more likely to delay marriage but were also more likely to eventually get married and stay married for more than 20 years (Copen, Daniels, & Mosher, 2013). Also in this study, Asian American women were the most likely of all ethnic groups to be in a first marriage that lasted at least 20 years—70 percent were in a first marriage that lasted this long, compared with 54 percent for non-Latina White women, 53 percent for Latina women, and 37 percent for Black American women.

Marital Trends

In 2021, 51.8 percent of adults in the United States were married, down from 72 percent in 1960 (U.S. Census Bureau, 2021). Also, in 2021, the U.S. average age for a first marriage had climbed to 30.4 years for men and 28.6 years for women, higher than at any other point in history (U.S. Census Bureau, 2021). In 1960, the average age for a first marriage in the United States was 23 years for men and 20 years for women.

The increased cohabitation rate in the United States has contributed to the lower percentage of adults who are married (Wang & Parker, 2014). Also, a higher percentage of U.S. adults never marry—in 2019, a record percentage (35 percent of men, 23 percent of women) of persons had never married (U.S. Census Bureau, 2021). Nevertheless, the United States is still a marrying society, with 78.5 percent of U.S. adults 25 years and older having been married at some point in their lives in 2016.

The age at which individuals get married is going up not just in the United States but also in many other countries. Also, in recent analyses, the average age at first marriage is higher in most developed countries than in the United States (OECD, 2019). For example, in a comparison of 39 developed countries, average age at first marriage now is higher in Sweden (34 for women and 36 for men) than in the other 38 countries. The lowest average age at first marriage in these developed countries is occurring in Israel and Turkey (25 for women and 27 for men). In most of the countries surveyed, individuals are getting married later than their counterparts in the United States, and in most countries marriage is occurring later than in previous decades.

Although marriage rates are declining and the average age of people entering their first marriage is going up, research with emerging and young adults indicates that they view marriage as a very important life pursuit. Indeed, in one study of young adults, they predicted that marriage would be more important in their life than parenting, careers, or leisure activities (Willoughby, Hall, & Goff, 2015). In the book, *The Marriage Paradox* (Willoughby & James, 2017), the authors concluded that the importance of marriage to emerging and young adults may be what is encouraging them to first establish a stronger career and financial foundation to increase the likelihood that their marriage will be successful. In this perspective, emerging and young adults may not be abandoning marriage because they don't like it or are uninterested in it, but because they want to increase their potential for developing a healthy marital relationship.

A recent survey explored why individuals get married (Geiger & Livingston, 2019). At the top of the list of reasons was love (88 percent), followed by making a lifelong commitment (81 percent), companionship (76 percent), and having children (49 percent). Another study explored what U.S. never-married men and women are looking for in a

potential spouse (Wang & Parker, 2014). Following are the percentages who reported that various factors would be very important for them:

Factor	Men	Women
Similar ideas about having and raising children	62	70
A steady job	46	78
Same moral and religious beliefs	31	38
At least as much education	26	28
Same racial or ethnic background	7	10

Thus, in this study, never-married men said that the most important characteristic of a potential spouse was similar ideas about having and raising children, but never-married women placed greater importance on having a partner with a steady job.

Is there a best age to get married? Marriages in adolescence are more likely to end in divorce than marriages in adulthood (Copen & others, 2012). However, researchers have not been able to pin down a specific age range for getting married that is most likely to result in a successful marriage (Furstenberg, 2007).

Premarital Education

Might premarital education programs improve the quality of a marriage and reduce the chances that the marriage will end in divorce? Researchers have found that they can (Markman, 2022). In a recent research review, premarital education benefited married couples' relationship quality, physical and mental health, coparenting, and the well-being of their children (Markman & others, 2022). In this review, it was found that high-risk couples benefited the most from premarital education. Low-income couples are especially unlikely to engage in relationship interventions despite being at greater risk for relationship dissolution (Gehart, 2024). One study of recently married low-income couples revealed that those who received premarital education were more likely to seek therapy to improve their relationship when the marriage became distressed than those who did not receive this education (Williamson & others, 2018).

A recent research analysis examined contemporary trends that influence the next generation's ability to form and sustain a positive marriage (Clyde, Hawkins, & Willoughby, 2020). The analysis also offered four proposals to improve the effectiveness of premarital education, as indicated in Figure 2.

How Would You...?

As a human development and family studies professional, what research-based material might you emphasize in premarital education?



Trend	Proposal
Individualism and Commitment Ambivalence	Premarital education needs to guide couples in transitioning from "me" to "we" and developing a strong commitment to their marriage.
Meaning of and Attitudes about Marriage	Premarital education should help individuals clarify for themselves and with their partner the meaning of marriage and their attitudes about it.
Premarital Relationship History and Experiences	Premarital education needs to focus on the complexities and challenges of marriage that many couples will experience as a result of considerable premarital experience, cohabitation, and premarital childbearing.
Effects of Media	Premarital education should help couples explore the effects of media use on marital attitudes and behavior.

Figure 2 Trends and Proposals for Improving Premarital Education in the Next Generation.

Source: After Clyde, Hawkins, and Willoughby (2020). Revising premarital relationship interventions for the next generation. *Journal of Marital and Family Therapy*.

The Benefits of a Good Marriage

Are there any benefits to having a good marriage? Yes. Individuals who are happily married live longer, healthier lives than individuals who are divorced or unhappily married (Gehart, 2024). In one research review, it was concluded that the experience of divorce or separation confers risk for poor health outcomes, including a 23 percent higher mortality rate (Sbarra, 2015). A survey of U.S. adults 50 years of age and older also revealed that a smaller portion of adult life spent in marriage was linked to an increased likelihood of dying at an earlier age (Henretta, 2010). Also, in a large-scale study conducted in the United States and six European countries, not being in the labor force was associated with higher mortality but marriage attenuated the increased mortality risk linked to labor force inactivity (Van Hedel & others, 2015). And a recent research review comparing the characteristics of individuals who were married, divorced, widowed, and single found that married individuals had the best cardiovascular profile and single men the worst (Manfredini & others, 2017). A recent study indicated that married individuals reported lower stress overload levels than those in any other type of relationship (single, in-a-relationship, or cohabiting) (Amirkhan & Vandenberg, 2023). Lower stress overload is one aspect, but not the only one, that may support better mental health in married individuals. Further, an unhappy marriage can shorten a person's life by an average of four years (Gove, Style, & Hughes, 1990). Perhaps people in happy marriages are likely to feel less stressed physically and emotionally, putting less wear and tear on their bodies. Such wear and tear can lead to numerous physical ailments, such as high blood pressure and heart disease, as well as psychological problems, such as anxiety, depression, and substance abuse.

Divorced Adults

In the 1980s divorce reached epidemic proportions in the United States. However, the divorce rate has declined in recent decades, peaking at 5.1 divorces per 1,000 people in 1981 and declining to 2.9 divorces per 1,000 in 2018 and dropping further to 2.0 divorces per 1,000 in 2021 (U.S. Census Bureau, 2021).

Although the divorce rate has dropped, the United States still has one of the highest divorce rates in the world. Russia has the highest divorce rate among the countries studied (4.7 divorces per 1,000 people in a single year), Chile the lowest (0.2 divorces per 1,000 people) (OECD, 2019). Individuals in some groups have higher rates of divorce (Perelli-Harris & others, 2017). Youthful marriage, low educational level, low income, not having a religious affiliation, having parents who are divorced, and having a baby before marriage are associated with increased rates of divorce (Hoelter, 2009). For

example, recent research in the United States revealed that wealthier couples have lower divorce risk (Killewald, Lee, & England, 2023). Why? Wealth may stabilize marriage by easing financial stress and providing resources for various life experiences. And certain characteristics of one's partner increase the likelihood of divorce: alcoholism, psychological problems, domestic violence, infidelity, inadequate division of household labor, and financial difficulties (Sbarra & Whisman, 2022).

Earlier, we indicated that researchers have not been able to pin down an ideal age to marry in order to reduce the likelihood of divorce. However, if a divorce is going to occur, it usually takes place early in a marriage, most often between the fifth and tenth years (National Center for Health Statistics, 2000) (see Figure 3). For example, one study found that divorce peaked in Finland approximately five to seven years into the marriage, followed by a gradual decline (Kulu, 2014). This timing may reflect an effort by partners in troubled marriages to stay in the marriage and try to

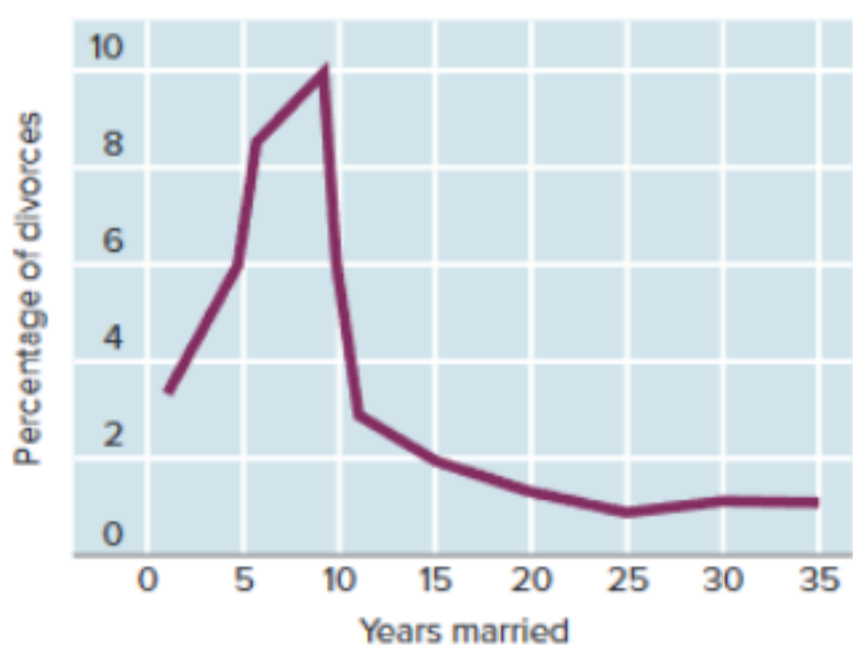


Figure 3 The Divorce Rate in Relation to Number of Years Married.

Shown here is the percentage of divorces as a function of how long couples have been married. Notice that most divorces occur in the early years of marriage, peaking in the 5th to 10th years of marriage.

work things out. If after several years these efforts have not improved the relationship, the couple may then seek a divorce.

What causes people to get divorced? A study in Great Britain found no differences in the causes of breakdowns in marriage and cohabitation (Gravningen & others, 2017). In this study, the following reasons for dissolving the relationship were cited: “grew apart” (men 39 percent, women 36 percent), “arguments” (men 27 percent, women 30 percent), “unfaithfulness/adultery” (men 18 percent, women 24 percent), “lack of respect, appreciation” (men 17 percent, women 25 percent), and “domestic violence” (men 4 percent, women 16 percent).

Both partners experience challenges after a marriage dissolves (Moons & others, 2021). Divorced adults have higher rates of depression, anxiety, physical illnesses, suicide, motor vehicle accidents, alcoholism, and mortality (Axinn & others, 2020). In a recent study, individuals who were divorced were at increased risk of having alcohol use disorder (Kendler & others, 2017). Also, both divorced women and divorced men complain of loneliness, diminished self-esteem, anxiety about the unknowns in their lives, and difficulty in forming satisfactory new intimate relationships (Sbarra & Whisman, 2022). One research review concluded that divorced men and women are more likely to commit suicide than their married counterparts (Yip & others, 2015). Also, a recent research review concluded that divorced adults have a higher rate of adverse cardiovascular events, including death due to cardiovascular disease, than their married counterparts (Dhindsa & others, 2020). A recent study of divorced adults found that autonomy, environmental mastery, self-acceptance, emotional self-regulation indicators, and motivation to achieve personality adjustment goals were associated with post-divorce life satisfaction (Lamela & Figueiredo, 2023).

There are gender differences in the process and outcomes of divorce (Daoulah & others, 2017). A recent study of couples who had been married from 1 to 16 years found that wives’ increased tension over the course of a marriage was consistently linked to an eventual divorce (Birditt & others, 2017). Partner violence also is associated with increased risk of divorce (Moodley & others, 2023). A recent Finnish study revealed that when divorcing women committed assaults against their husbands, these were mostly accompanied by victimization, suggesting that resistant violence was common when women were perpetrators (Einio & others, 2023). Thus, women with a history of victimization need support, especially early in the divorce process. Women are more likely to sense that something is wrong with the marriage and are more likely to seek a divorce than are men. Women also show better emotional adjustment and are more likely to perceive divorce as a “second chance” to increase their happiness, improve their social lives, and seek better work opportunities. However, divorce typically has a more negative economic impact on women than on men.

Remarried Adults

Adults who remarry usually do so rather quickly, with approximately 50 percent remarrying within three years after the divorce (U.S. Census Bureau, 2021). Between 1990 and 2019, the U.S. remarriage rate decreased by 50 percent. Between 2008 and 2019, remarriage experienced a 25 percent reduction. Thus, with each decade, significantly fewer divorced people are choosing to enter a subsequent marriage. One reason for the decline is the dramatic increase in cohabitation in recent years. Also, while approximately 50 percent of first-time marriages end in divorce, the figure increases to 67 percent for second marriages and 74 percent for third marriages. Further, men remarry sooner than women. The remarriage rate for men in 2019 was 31.5 per 1,000 men eligible for remarriage. The rate for women was much lower, at 19.4 per 1,000 women eligible for remarriage (U.S. Census Bureau, 2021). Also, men with higher incomes are more likely to remarry than their counterparts with lower incomes. And remarriage occurs sooner for partners who initiate a divorce (especially in the first several years after divorce and for older women) than for those who do not initiate it.

What are some reasons for getting remarried? Divorced or widowed adults may choose to remarry because they have met someone and fallen in love with them, they want a higher standard of living, they don’t like living alone, they believe they will be

happier if they are married, or they feel that they have learned what doesn't work in a failed marriage and can apply that knowledge in their next marriage.

What are some of the difficulties faced by remarried adults? A recent study found that it is not unusual for remarried adults to carry negative patterns that produced failure in an earlier marriage into their current remarried relationship (Yazdani & others, 2021). Remarried couples also experience more stress in rearing children than parents in never-divorced families (Bray, 2019). And one study found that remarried adults had less frequent sex than those in their first marriage (Stroope, McFarland, & Uecker, 2015).

LGBTQ Adults

Until recently, the legal context of marriage created barriers to breaking up that did not exist for same-sex partners. However, the legalization of same-sex marriage in all 50 states in 2015 extended this barrier to same-sex partners. In many additional ways, researchers have found that gay and lesbian relationships are similar—in their satisfactions, loves, joys, and conflicts—to heterosexual relationships (Balsam, Rostosky, & Riggle, 2017). For example, a recent study indicated that adults in same-sex relationships were experiencing similar levels of commitment, satisfaction, and emotional intimacy as their counterparts in different-sex relationships (Joyner, Manning, & Prince, 2019). Also, an increasing number of gay and lesbian couples are creating families that include children (Goldberg, 2023).



How Would You...?

As a social psychologist, what research-based information might you use to make the case that same-sex relationships are similar to different-sex relationships?

Data from the American Community Survey conducted from 2006 to 2010 indicate that among same-sex couples in the United States, lesbian couples are approximately five times more likely to be raising children than are gay couples (Miller & Price, 2013). An increasing number of same-sex couples are adopting children (Cashen & others, 2023).

Also, research indicates that lesbian and gay couples share child care more than heterosexual couples do, with lesbian couples being the most supportive and gay couples the least supportive (Farr & others, 2023). Also, one survey found that a greater percentage of same-sex, dual-earner couples than different-sex couples said they share laundry (44 versus 31 percent), household repairs (33 versus 15 percent), and routine (74 versus 38 percent) and sick (62 versus 32 percent) child-care responsibilities (Matos, 2015).

There are a number of misconceptions about gay and lesbian couples (Goldberg, 2023). Contrary to stereotypes, one partner is masculine and the other feminine in only a small percentage of gay and lesbian couples. Only a small segment of the gay population has a large number of sexual partners, and this is uncommon among lesbians. Furthermore, researchers have found that gay and lesbian couples prefer long-term, committed relationships (Fingerhut & Peplau, 2013). About half of committed gay couples do have an open relationship that allows the possibility of sex (but not affectionate love) outside of the relationship. Lesbian couples usually do not have an open relationship.

A special concern is the stigma, prejudice, and discrimination that lesbian, gay, and bisexual individuals experience because of widespread social devaluation of same-sex relationships (Malta, 2023). However, researchers have found that many individuals in these relationships see stigma as bringing them closer together and strengthening their relationship (Frost, 2011).

Challenges in Marriage, Parenting, and Divorce

No matter what lifestyles young adults choose, their choices will bring certain challenges. Because many choose the lifestyle of marriage, we'll consider some of the challenges of marriage and describe elements of successful marriages. We will also examine

some challenges of parenting and trends in childbearing. Given the statistics about divorce rates in the previous section, we'll then consider how to deal with divorce.

Making Marriage Work

John Gottman (2011, 2023) uses many methods to analyze what makes marriages work. He interviews couples about the history of their marriage, their philosophy about marriage, and how they view their parents' marriages. He videotapes them talking to each other about how their day went and evaluates what they say about the good and bad times of their marriages. Gottman also uses physiological measures to chart their heart rate, blood flow, blood pressure, and immune functioning from moment to moment. In addition, he checks back with the couples every year to see how their marriage is faring. Gottman's research represents the most extensive assessment of marital relationships available. Currently, he and his colleagues are following 700 couples in seven studies.

Among the principles Gottman has found that determine whether a marriage will work are the following (Gottman & Silver, 2000):

- *Establishing love maps.* Individuals in successful marriages have personal insights and detailed maps of each other's life and world. They aren't psychological strangers. In good marriages, partners are willing to share their feelings with each other. They use these "love maps" to express not only their understanding of each other but also their fondness and admiration.
- *Nurturing fondness and admiration.* In successful marriages, partners sing each other's praises. More than 90 percent of the time, when couples put a positive spin on their marriage's history, the marriage is likely to have a positive future.
- *Turning toward each other instead of away.* In good marriages, spouses are adept at turning toward each other regularly. They see each other as friends. This friendship doesn't keep arguments from occurring, but it can prevent differences from overwhelming the relationship. In these good marriages, spouses respect each other and appreciate each other's point of view despite disagreements.
- *Letting your partner influence you.* Bad marriages often involve one spouse who is unwilling to share power with the other. Although power-mongering is more common in husbands, some wives also show this trait. A willingness to share power and to respect the other person's view is a prerequisite to compromising.
- *Creating shared meaning.* The more partners can speak candidly and respectfully with each other, the more likely they are to create shared meaning in their marriage. This also includes sharing goals with one's spouse and working together to achieve each other's goals.



What makes marriages work? What are the benefits of having a good marriage?

Image Source/Alamy Stock Photo

In a provocative book titled *Marriage, a History: How Love Conquered Marriage*, Stephanie Coontz (2005) concluded that marriages in America today are fragile not because Americans have become self-centered and career-minded but because expectations for marriage have become unrealistically high compared with expectations held by previous generations. To make a marriage work, Coontz emphasizes like Gottman that partners need to develop a deep friendship, show respect for each other, and embrace commitment.



How Would You...?

As a human development and family studies professional, what research-based information would you share with recently married couples about how to make a marriage work?

In addition to Gottman's view, other experts on marriage argue that factors such as forgiveness and commitment are important aspects of a successful marriage (Lavner & Bradbury, 2019). These factors function as self-repair processes in healthy relationships. For example, spouses may have a heated argument that has the potential to harm their relationship. After calming down, they may forgive each other and repair the damage.

Spouses with a strong commitment to each other may in times of conflict sacrifice their personal self-interest for the benefit of the marriage (Norouzi & others, 2022). Commitment is especially important when a couple is not happily married because it can help them get through hard times with the hope that the future will involve positive changes in the relationship.

A couple's personality traits also may influence how satisfied they are with their marriage. For example, a recent study found that couples high in neuroticism were less satisfied with their marriages than couples high in conscientiousness (Sayehmiri & others, 2020).

How important is the sexual aspect of a relationship in the couple's marital satisfaction? A recent study of couples in their second to fourteenth years of marriage found that frequency of engaging in sexual intercourse was linked to a couple's marital satisfaction, but that a satisfying sex life and a warm interpersonal relationship were more important than frequency (Schoenfeld & others, 2017).

Becoming a Parent

For many young adults, parental roles are well planned, coordinated with other roles in life, and developed with the couple's economic situation in mind. For others, the discovery that they are about to become parents is a startling surprise. In either event, the prospective parents may have mixed emotions and romantic illusions about having a child (Perry-Jenkins & Schoppe-Sullivan, 2019).

Parenting requires a number of interpersonal skills and imposes emotional demands, yet there is little in the way of formal education for this task (Riggs & Bartholomaeus, 2023). Most parents learn parenting practices from their own parents—some they accept, some they discard. Unfortunately, when parenting practices are passed on from one generation to the next, both desirable and undesirable practices are perpetuated. Adding to the challenges of the task of parenting, husbands and wives may bring different parenting practices to the marriage. In such cases the parents may disagree about the best ways to interact with a child.

Parent educators seek to help individuals become better parents. To read about the work of one parent educator, see *Careers in Life-Span Development*.

In addition to waiting longer to get married than their parents and grandparents did, people in the United States are postponing parenthood. In 2019, the median age for women giving birth was the highest it has ever been: 30 years of age (U.S. Census Bureau, 2022). As the use of contraception has become widespread, many individuals choose when they will have children and how many children they will rear. The number of one-child families is increasing, for example, and U.S. women overall are having fewer children. These childbearing results are creating several trends:

- By giving birth to fewer children and reducing the demands of child care, women are freeing up a significant portion of their life spans for other endeavors.
- Mothers are spending more of their time at work, leaving them with less time to invest in their children's development.
- Men are investing a greater amount of time in fathering than previous generations did.
- Parental care for children is often supplemented by institutional care (child care, for example).

As more women show an increased interest in developing a career, they are not only marrying later but also having fewer children and having them later in life. What

Careers in life-span development

Janis Keyser, Parent Educator

Janis Keyser is a parent educator who has taught early childhood education classes, conducted parenting workshops, and contributed videos and articles to parenting Web sites such as *Kids in the House*. Keyser has also authored parenting books such as *From Parents to Partners: Building a Family-Centered Early Childhood Program* (2017) and *Becoming the Parent You Want to Be: A Sourcebook of Strategies for the First Five Years* (1997, with Laura Davis).

Parent educators coach parents and caregivers on how to raise physically and emotionally healthy children. They work in public and private schools, child-care centers, family centers, and other providers of family support care. Often, they are called on to help a family in crisis or because a court has recommended parent education courses as a requirement for visitation rights.



Janis Keyser (right) conducts a parenting workshop. Courtesy of Janis Keyser

Parent educators have a degree or certification in family counseling, social work, or a related field. Although requirements vary by state, most states that regulate the profession require a master's degree and relevant experience prior to licensure.

are some of the advantages of having children early or late? Some of the advantages of having children early (in the twenties) are that the parents are likely to have more physical energy (for example, they can cope better with such matters as getting up in the middle of the night with infants and waiting up until adolescents come home at night); the mother is likely to have fewer medical problems with pregnancy and childbirth; and the parents may be less likely to build up expectations for their children, as do many couples who have waited a long time to have children.

There are also advantages to having children later (in the thirties). These parents have had more time to consider and achieve some of their goals in life and to determine what they want from their family and career roles. Older parents also are more mature and able to benefit from their life experiences to engage in more competent parenting, and they are more securely established in their careers and tend to have more income for child-rearing expenses than younger parents do.



What are some trends in having children?
Ryan McVay/Photodisc/Getty Images

Dealing with Divorce

If a marriage doesn't work, what happens after divorce? Psychologically, one of the most common characteristics of divorced adults is difficulty trusting someone else in a romantic relationship. Following a divorce, though, people's lives can take diverse turns (Sbarra & Whisman, 2022). For example, in one research study 20 percent of the divorced group became more competent and better adjusted following their divorce (Hetherington & Kelly, 2002).

Strategies for divorced adults include the following (Hetherington & Kelly, 2002):

- Think of divorce as a chance to grow personally and to develop more positive relationships.
- Make decisions carefully, realizing that the consequences of your decisions regarding work, lovers, and children may last a lifetime.
- Focus more on the future than the past. Think about what is most important for you going forward in your life, set some challenging goals, and plan how to reach them.

- Use your strengths and resources to cope with difficulties.
- Don't expect to be successful and happy in everything you do. The path to a more enjoyable life will likely have a number of twists and turns, and moving forward will require considerable effort and resilience.

Gender and Communication Styles, Relationships, and Classification

In our discussion of children's socioemotional development, we described many aspects of gender development. Gender continues to be a very important aspect of adults' lives and their development. Here we discuss the communication styles of males and females, how males and females relate to others, how gender is classified for cisgender, nonbinary, and transgender individuals.



What are some strategies for coping with divorce?
Image Source/Getty Images

Gender and Communication Styles

Stereotypes about differences in men's and women's attitudes toward communication and about differences in how they communicate with each other have spawned countless cartoons and jokes. Are the supposed differences real or exaggerated? When Deborah Tannen (1990) analyzed the talk of women and men, she found that many wives complained about their husbands by saying, "He doesn't listen to me anymore" and "He doesn't talk to me anymore." Lack of communication, although high on women's lists of reasons for divorce, is mentioned much less often by men.

Communication problems between men and women may reflect differences in their preferred ways of communicating. Tannen distinguishes *rapport talk* from *report talk*. **Rapport talk** is the language of conversation; it is a way of establishing connections and negotiating relationships. **Report talk** is talk that is designed to give information; this category of communication includes public speaking. According to Tannen, women enjoy rapport talk more than report talk, and men's lack of interest

in rapport talk bothers many women. In contrast, men prefer to engage in report talk. Men hold center stage through verbal performances, telling stories and jokes to get and keep attention.

How extensive are gender differences in communication? Research has yielded somewhat mixed results, but some gender differences have been found (Anderson, 2006). One study of a sampling of students' e-mails found that people could guess the writer's gender correctly two-thirds of the time (Thompson & Murachver, 2001). Another study revealed that women make 63 percent of phone calls and

when talking to another woman stay on the phone longer (7.2 minutes) than men do when talking with other men (4.6 minutes) (Smoreda & Licoppe, 2000). However, meta-analyses suggest that overall gender differences in communication are small in both children and adults (Hyde, 2014; Leaper & Smith, 2004).

rapport talk Use of conversation to establish connections and maintain relationships.

report talk Talk that is designed to convey information.



What are some differences in women's and men's communication styles?
Eric Audras/Onoky/SuperStock

Gender and Relationships

As in childhood and adolescence, there are gender differences in friendship during adulthood (Blieszner & Ogletree, 2017). Compared with men, women have more close friends and their friendships involve more self-disclosure and mutual support (Dow & Wood, 2006). Women are more likely to listen at length to what a friend has to say and be sympathetic, and women have been labeled as “talking companions” because talk is so central to their relationships (Gouldner & Strong, 1987). Women’s friendships tend to be characterized not only by depth but also by breadth: Women share many aspects of their experiences, thoughts, and feelings (Crawford, 2023). When female friends get together, they like to talk, but male friends are more likely to engage in activities, especially outdoors. Thus, the adult male pattern of friendship often involves keeping one’s distance while sharing useful information. Men are less likely than women to talk about their weaknesses with their friends, and men seek practical solutions to their problems rather than sympathy (Tannen, 1990). Also, adult male friendships are more competitive than those of women (Matlin & Foushee, 2023).

What are some characteristics of cross-gender friendships? Cross-gender friendships are more common among adults than children but less common than same-gender friendships in adulthood (Blieszner, 2009). Cross-gender friendships can provide both opportunities and problems. The opportunities involve learning more about common feelings and interests and shared characteristics, as well as acquiring knowledge and understanding of beliefs and activities that historically have been typical of the other gender.

Problems can arise in cross-gender friendships because of different expectations. One problem that can plague an adult cross-gender friendship is unclear sexual boundaries, which can produce tension and confusion (Hart, Adams, & Tullett, 2016).

Gender Classification

Gender can be classified in multiple ways. In recent years, emphasis has been placed on flexibility and equality in gender roles (Matlin & Foushee, 2023).

When individuals have a gender identity that aligns with their sex assigned at birth, they may be categorized as *cisgender* (Reiman, Ocasio, & Mezzapelle, 2023). In contrast, **transgender** is a broad term that refers to individuals whose gender identity differs from the gender typically associated with their sex assigned at birth (Doyle, 2023). For example, an individual may be assigned female at birth and identify as a boy or man, or be assigned male at birth and identify as a girl or woman. An individual may also be assigned female or male and identify as another gender outside of the girl/woman versus boy/man gender binary. A transgender identity of being assigned a boy or a man but identifying as a girl or woman is much more common than the reverse (Zucker, Lawrence, & Kreukels, 2016).

Because of the nuances and complexities involved in gender categorizations, some experts have recently argued that a better overarching umbrella term might be *trans* or *gender diverse* to identify a variety of gender identities and expressions different from the gender typically associated with the sex that was assigned at birth (Lee & Rosenthal, 2023). The diverse range of gender identities includes binary transgender identities (for example, transgender girl/woman, transgender boy/man) and nonbinary gender identities (individuals who have a gender identity that is outside the girl/woman and boy/man binary, such as gender-queer individuals who are neither exclusively masculine nor exclusively feminine and gender-nonconforming individuals whose behavior/appearance does not conform to social expectations for what is appropriate for their gender). Transgender persons with a nonbinary identity may prefer a gender-neutral pronoun such as “they” or “ze” rather than “he” or “she.”

In addition, the term *two-spirit* is used by some indigenous North Americans to describe gender-diverse individuals who are perceived to have spirits from both women and men (Kinitz & others, 2022). Although the term “transsexual” has been used historically to refer to transgender people, it is now regarded as outdated and may be perceived as offensive by some transgender individuals.

transgender A broad term that refers to individuals who have a gender identity that differs from the gender typically associated with their sex assigned at birth.



What characterizes transgender individuals?
FatCamera/Stock/Getty Images



How Would You...?

As a **counseling psychologist**, what research-based and current information would you share with parents who are struggling with understanding what “gender identity” means?

Among individuals who identify themselves as transgender persons, the majority eventually adopt a gender identity in line with the body into which they were born (King, 2023). Some transgender individuals seek gender-affirming surgery to change their physical body to more closely match their gender identity, but many do not (Giordano & Horowicz, 2023). Some choose to receive hormonal treatments, such as assigned females who use testosterone to enhance their masculine physical characteristics or assigned males who use estrogen to increase their feminine physical characteristics. Yet other transgender individuals opt for another, broader strategy that involves choosing a lifestyle that challenges the traditional view of having a gender identity that fits within one of two opposing categories (Waryold & Kornahrens, 2020).

A special concern is discrimination directed against trans individuals (Eom & others, 2022). A recent study found that a majority of transgender individuals had experienced discrimination in the last year and those with greater exposure to discrimination were more likely to develop depression and anxiety symptoms (Puckett & others, 2020). Estimates indicate that 40 percent or more of transgender individuals have attempted suicide at least once in their lives (Dickey & Budge, 2020). A research review concluded that transgender youth have higher rates of depression, suicide attempts, and eating disorders than their cisgender peers (Connolly & others, 2016). Among the explanations for higher rates of mental health concerns are the distress of living in the wrong body and the discrimination and misunderstanding encountered by gender-minority individuals (Yockey, King, & Vidourek, 2022). In a recent study of transgender individuals, gender affirmation—being recognized as one’s gender identity, gender expression, or gender role—was associated with a lower probability of suicidal ideation and psychological distress, while discrimination was linked to a higher probability of suicidal ideation and psychological distress (Lelutiu-Weinberger, English, & Sandanapitchai, 2020). And another recent study confirmed that victimization and discrimination against transgender individuals predicted an increase in their suicidal ideation, while community connectedness reduced their suicidal ideation (Rabasco & Andover, 2021).

Because transgender individuals experience considerable discrimination, it is important that society provide a more welcoming and accepting attitude toward them (Coulter-Thompson & others, 2023). Also, recent research indicates that psychotherapy targeting internalized stigma and non-affirmation experiences can be effective in reducing gender-related stress and improving resilience (Budge, Sinnard, & Hoyt, 2020). To read about one individual who conducts research and psychotherapy with transgender individuals, see the *Careers in Life-Span Development* interlude.

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Going Beyond Gender as Binary

In a number of places in our coverage of gender, we have indicated that the long-existing (for more than a century) concept of gender as having just two categories—boys/men and girls/women—is being challenged. In a recent analysis, leading expert Janet Shibley Hyde and her colleagues (2019) described a number of aspects of gender where this challenge is occurring. These include the following developments: (1) Neuroscience research indicates the presence of a gender mosaic rather than “his or her” brains that are highly different; (2) endocrinology research reveals more hormonal similarities in males and females than had been previously envisioned; (3) recent conceptual changes in gender role classification go far beyond characterizing individuals as masculine or feminine and add a number of new gender identity categories such as transgender and nonbinary; (4) developmental research indicates that the tendency to view gender as a binary category is not due only to biological factors but also culturally determined and malleable. Further, gender categories are not mutually exclusive—an individual can identify with more than one category. Also, gender categories are fluid because an individual’s gender identity can change over time. Each of the ideas described here reflects a substantial change in how gender is conceptualized and reflected in individuals’ daily lives, but as we indicated earlier in the chapter, there is still controversy about the extent of gender similarities and differences.

Careers in life-span development

Stephanie Budge, Psychotherapist Specializing in Transgender Research

Dr. Stephanie Budge is a leading expert on transgender research, issues, and psychotherapy. She is a professor in the Department of Counseling at the University of Wisconsin–Madison, where she obtained her Ph.D. in counseling psychology. Her research focuses on emotional development and coping in transgender youth and adults, as well as the use of psychotherapy with transgender clients. Dr. Budge also works nationally and internationally in training individuals to provide help related to LGBTQ issues, with a focus on increasing practitioners' self-efficacy, knowledge, and skills.

At the University of Wisconsin–Madison, Dr. Budge has given *pro bono* therapy to transgender youth and adults. Dr. Budge has received the LGBTQ Outstanding Community Contributions award from the American Psychological Association and the LGBT Early Career Award from the Society for Counseling Psychology. She is currently associate editor of two journals: *Psychotherapy* and *Psychology of Sexual Orientation and Gender Diversity*. Dr. Budge also serves on the editorial board of the *International Journal of Transgender Health*.



Dr. Stephanie Budge is a leading expert on transgender youth and adults.
Dr. Stephanie Budge

Summary

Stability and Change from Childhood to Adulthood

- The first 20 years of life are important in predicting an adult's personality, but experiences after age 20 also influence development.
- Attachment styles reflect childhood patterns and continue to influence relationships in adulthood. Adult attachments are categorized as secure, avoidant, or anxious. A secure attachment style is linked with positive aspects of relationships.

Love and Close Relationships

- Erikson theorized that intimacy versus isolation is the key developmental issue in early adulthood.
- Friendship plays an important role in adult development, especially in terms of emotional support.
- Romantic love, also called passionate love, includes passion, sexuality, and a mixture of emotions, not all of which are positive. Affectionate love, also called companionate love, usually becomes more important as relationships mature.
- Sternberg proposed a triarchic model of love: passion, intimacy, and commitment. If all three qualities are present, the result is consummate love.

Adult Lifestyles

- Being single has become an increasingly prominent lifestyle. Autonomy is one of its advantages. Challenges

faced by single adults include achieving intimacy, coping with loneliness, and finding a positive identity in a marriage-oriented society.

- Cohabitation, an increasingly popular lifestyle, does not lead to greater marital happiness but sometimes is linked to possible negative consequences if a cohabiting couple marries.
- The age at which individuals marry in the United States is increasing. Though marriage rates have declined, a large percentage of Americans still marry. Premarital education has been shown to produce positive marital outcomes. The benefits of marriage include better physical and mental health and a longer life.
- The U.S. divorce rate increased dramatically in the middle of the twentieth century but began to decline in the 1980s.
- Divorce is a complex and emotionally challenging experience.
- Stepfamilies are complex, and adjustment is difficult. Evidence on the benefits of remarriage after divorce is mixed.
- One of the most striking research findings about gay and lesbian couples is how similar their relationships are to heterosexual couples' relationships.

Challenges In Marriage, Parenting, and Divorce

- Gottman’s research indicates that couples in successful marriages establish love maps, nurture fondness and admiration, turn toward each other, accept the influence of the partner, and create shared meaning.
- Families are becoming smaller, and many women are delaying childbirth until they have become well established in a career.
- Divorced adults often have difficulty trusting their partners in subsequent romantic relationships. Certain strategies are effective in dealing with divorce.

Gender and Communication Styles, Relationships, and Classification

- Tannen distinguishes between report talk, which many men prefer, and rapport talk, which many women prefer;

however, meta-analyses have found only small gender differences in overall communication patterns.

- Gender differences characterize adult friendships. Female friends tend to share their experiences, thoughts, and feelings, while male friends tend to be more competitive and to keep some emotional distance while sharing useful information.
- In recent years, emphasis has been placed on flexibility and equality in gender roles. Transgender individuals adopt a gender identity different from the one assigned to them at birth. Gender is recognized as being more like a mosaic than a binary concept.

Key Terms

affectionate love	avoidant attachment style	report talk	secure attachment style
anxious attachment style	rapport talk	romantic love	transgender